

Research methods

Experiments

An experiment is a method in which the researcher changes one variable and measures its effect on another.

The independent variable is the variable the researcher changes. The dependent variable is the variable the researcher measures.

Laboratory experiments take place in controlled conditions, so they have high internal validity.

Confounding variables

Confounding variables are variables other than the independent variable that change along with it and affect the dependent variable.

Confounding variables make it impossible to know what caused a change in the results.

Random allocation of participants to conditions reduces the effect of confounding variables.

Sampling

A sample is the group of people who take part in a study, chosen from the target population.

Random sampling means every member of the target population has an equal chance of being chosen.

Opportunity sampling uses whoever is available at the time, which is quick but may be biased.